

Interview on a Good Life

When I first heard about this interview assignment, my mind immediately went to one person and that was my mother. At 46 years old, she has lived a life that spans two continents, two cultures, and more challenges than most people face in a lifetime. Sitting down to interview her about what makes a good life felt both exciting and slightly intimidating. How do you ask someone who raised you to explain the wisdom that shapes who you are? But as we settled onto my favorite couch last Sunday evening, I realized this was not just an assignment but an opportunity to truly listen to the woman I thought I already knew everything about.

About My Interview Subject

My mother, Noushin Taghavi, was born and raised in Iran. She was born on September 9th, 1979. She spent the first 36 years of her life there before making the difficult decision to move to the United States ten years ago. Today she lives in Cary, North Carolina, with my father and me, and works at Amazon. But these basic facts only scratch the surface of who she is. My mother has always had a deep passion for environmental issues. She spent years researching environmental topics and even translated numerous books from English to Farsi about environmental engineering and related subjects. This work was more than just a job for her. It was a way to contribute to something she believed in deeply. When she talks about the environment, her whole face lights up with the kind of enthusiasm most others reserve for talking about their children. She is the kind of individual who notices everything, who can find beauty in the smallest details, and who never stops learning.

I am her only child, and growing up, I watched her navigate the challenges of building a new life in a new country where everything from the language to the culture was unfamiliar. She faced these challenges with a quiet strength that I have always admired but never fully understood until this interview.

The Interview

I conducted this interview on Sunday, March 29th, 2026, at 7:00 pm. We sat on the long couch in our living room. My mother made tea, and we settled in

for what turned out to be an hour long conversation that revealed layers of her thinking I had never fully appreciated before. The interview felt less like a formal question and answer session and more like one of our regular talks, except this time I was asking different questions and really paying attention to not just what she said but how she said it. I asked her about happiness, purpose, regrets, and what she believes makes life worth living. Her answers were thoughtful, honest, and deeply personal.

What makes a good life?

My mother took a moment before answering this question, looking down at her tea as if she was gathering her thoughts. When she finally started to talk, her voice was calm and measured. Then she said “A good life is having peace in your heart, being close to your family, and feeling thankful for what you have. It is not just about money or success. It is about love, respect, and loving honesty.”

As she said this, I realized how much her answer reflected the life she has actually lived. She left behind a comfortable life in Iran, not for money or status, but to build a better future for our family. She works hard at her job, but she never talks about work as the source of her happiness. Instead, she talks about the moments we spend together and the simple fact that we are all healthy and safe.

What is the most important aspect of life?

Without any hesitation, she said “The most important aspect of life is family. Family members are the ones who stay with you in hard times and support you. They are the ones that give you days meaning. Without that connection, other things do not feel important.”

When she made the decision to leave Iran, she left behind her extended family, her friends, her entire life she had built with my father. She knows firsthand what it feels like to be without that daily connection to the loved ones who shaped her. And yet, or maybe because of that, she had built such a strong bond with my father and me. We are a small family, just the three of us, but the connection between us is everything to her.

What brings you the most joy?

I could see her smile appearing as she was going to answer the question. She said “What brings me the most joy is seeing you healthy and happy in your life and i think that really gives me the deepest happiness. Even small moments together mean a lot to me.”

In that moment, I felt the full weight of her love and her constant care about my well being and her joy is not contingent on big achievements or milestones. It lives in everyday moments, in the fact that we can sit together and share a meal, that we can laugh together, that we are all here and healthy.

What life experience has been most valuable to you?

This question made her pause longer than any other one. I could see that she was reflecting over her years of living. When she finally started to speak, she said “The most valuable life experience for me was leaving behind the place where I was born and learning how to build a life from zero. Growing up in Iran and then facing different struggles later taught me patience and strength, and how important it is to keep going even when life is not easy.”

I had heard pieces of her story before, but hearing her say it as her most valuable teaching hit me differently. Immigration is not just a change of location. It is a complete reimagining of who you are and how you fit in the world. She had to learn a new language, make new friends and connections, build a career from scratch, all while maintaining me and her self's connection to where she came from. These are the things she has had to do every day for the past ten years.

What advice would you give for living a good life?

I could tell this question was something she had thought about deeply before since she said right away by saying “Stay consistent with whatever you want to do and make sure to finish what you have started. Many people begin things with motivation, but the important part is continuing even when it gets hard. For me, a good life comes from patience and not giving up halfway.

This advice feels so characteristic of her. She is not someone who chases excitement or novelty. She is someone who commits to things and sees them through. Whether it is her work, her family, or her personal projects, she finishes what she starts I think about how she spent years translating those environmental engineering books, work that was meticulous and often

tedious, but she completed every single one because she believed it mattered. She always knows to stay consistent and to follow through.

Do you have any regrets?

This was the question I was most interested in asking her. Regret is such a heavy topic, and I was not sure how she would respond. She thought for a second, then answered by saying “Yeah, I have some regrets because every person does. Sometimes I wish I worried less and enjoyed certain moments more. But I also believe regrets teach you something, so I try not to live in the past. I try to learn from it and be thankful for what life has given me.”

Her answer surprised me because she agreed that she has regrets but she said she doesn’t want to live in the past. She knows them, learns from them, and moves forward with gratitude. This balance between honesty about her mistakes and refusal to dive on them feels like another form of wisdom I am still trying to learn.

Analysis and Connections to Course Content

Reflecting on this interview, I am struck by how directly my mother’s responses connect to the central themes we have explored throughout this course in The Happiness Hypothesis. Her emphasis on family as the most important aspect of life shows exactly what we learned from Robert Waldinger’s TED Talk about what makes a good life. Waldinger’s research, which followed people for over 75 years found that the quality of our relationships is the single strongest predictor of happiness and health. People who are more connected to family, friends, and community are happier, healthier, and live longer than people who are isolated.

My mother’s life shows this truth in a strong way. When she talks about family giving life meaning and being the people who stay with you in hard times, she is not speaking theoretically. She lived through the experience of leaving her extended family in Iran and building a new life with just my father and me. That small family unit became everything to her precisely because she understands what it feels like to lose those daily connections with loved ones.

Her response about regrets also connects to concepts from Chapter 7 of the Happiness Hypothesis, which discussed the uses of adversity and post traumatic growth. Haidt explained that while trauma and difficulty can break us they can also make us stronger if we process them correctly. People who successfully work through adversity often emerge with greater appreciation for life, stronger relationships, and a clearer sense of what truly matters. My mother's approach to regrets shows this kind of growth. She does not deny that she had regrets or pretended everything worked out perfectly. She acknowledges that she sometimes worried too much and missed opportunities to enjoy moments more. But instead of letting those regrets paralyze her or define her identity, she treats them as something she should learn from. She learns her lesson and then moves on with gratitude. This is exactly the kind of post traumatic growth Haidt describes, where painful experiences become opportunities for deeper wisdom rather than sources of ongoing suffering.

The way she described her immigration experience as her most valuable life experience also shows post traumatic growth. Leaving Iran was not something she did easily. It involved so many sacrifices and years of struggle. She had to rebuild her entire life from the ground up in a foreign country where she did not speak the language fluently and did not have an established career. These were so many difficult circumstances that could have broken her spirit. Instead, she describes this experience as something that taught her patience, and how to stay strong. She was transformed by the challenge rather than being defeated by them. Haidt would call this adversarial growth, where struggle becomes the catalyst for developing capabilities and insights that would not have emerged otherwise.

My mother's advice about consistency and finishing what you start connects to the concept of grit that we explored in our course. The idea that success comes not from initial motivation, but from sustained effort over time, especially when things get difficult, is central to understanding achievement and life satisfaction. Angela Duckworth's research on grit shows that preference and passion for long term goals are better predictors of success than talent or IQ. My mother embodies this principle completely. She does not talk about life in terms of big moments or lucky breaks. She talks about it in terms of daily commitment, patience, and refusing to give up halfway

through. This mindset allowed her to complete years of translation work on environmental engineering books, work that required enormous focus and dedication. It allowed her to build a stable life in a new country despite all the obstacles. And it continues to guide how she approaches everything from her work at Amazon to her role as a mother.

Her definition of a good life as having peace in your heart, being close to family, and feeling thankful for what you have aligned with Chapter 10 of The Happiness Hypothesis, which argues that happiness comes from between. Haidt explains that meaning and happiness do not come solely from within us or from external achievements, but from the connections and relationships between ourselves and others, between ourselves and our work or even bigger ourselves and something larger than ourselves. My mother's emphasis on peace, family connection, and gratitude reflects this understanding. She does not define a good life in terms of individual accomplishment or material success. She defines it in relational and spiritual terms, in terms of inner contentment and connection to others.

The interview also made me think about the article we read, Talk Less, Listen more by Kate Murphy. Murphy argues that real listening has become a lost art, and that genuinely listening to someone is one of the most powerful gifts we can give. During this interview, I tried to practice the kind of listening Murphy describes, where you are not just waiting for your turn to talk or think about what you want to say next, but really paying attention to what the other person is communicating. I noticed things in my mother's responses that I might have missed in our regular conversation. The pauses before she answered certain questions. The way her voice changed when she talked about immigration. The quiet pride when she discussed the importance of finishing what you start. These details gave me a deeper understanding of not just what she believes, but why she believes it and how those beliefs have been shaped by her experiences.

What strikes me most about this interview is how my mother's wisdom is not theoretical or abstract. It comes from lived experience, from real struggles and real choices. When she talks about the importance of family, she speaks as someone who left her family behind and knows what that loss feels like. When she talks about patience and perseverance, she speaks like someone

who rebuilt her life from nothing in a foreign country. When she talks about leaning from regrets rather than being trapped by them, she speaks as someone who has made mistakes and chosen to grow from them. This kind of wisdom cannot be found in books or lectures. It can only come from living through challenges and reflecting deeply on what those challenges taught you.

This interview has changed how I see my mother. I have always known she was strong and wise, but I had never fully understood the intentional philosophy that guides her life. Her emphasis on consistency, her prioritization of family relationships, her practice of extracting lessons from difficult experiences rather than being defeated by them; these are not things that just happened to her. They are choices she makes every single day. She chooses gratitude over resentment. She chooses connection over isolation. She chooses to keep going even when things are hard. These choices have shaped not just her own life, but mine as well. Growing up with a mother who modeled this kind of resilience and intentionality has given me a foundation I am only now beginning to fully appreciate.

The interview also deepened my engagement with our course material. Reading about post-traumatic growth or the importance of relationships is one thing. Seeing how those concepts play out in real life, in the life of someone I love and admire, is something else entirely. My mother is a living example of so many principles we have studied. She shows that happiness really does come from between, from our connections to others and to meaningful work. She shows that adversity can be transformative rather than just destructive. She shows that consistency and commitment matter more than initial enthusiasm. And she shows that gratitude and peace of mind are choices we make rather than conditions we stumble into.

Most importantly, this interview reminded me that I do not need to look far to find examples of wisdom about living a good life. My mother, who I see every day and sometimes take for granted, has been living these principles all long. She immigrated to a new country, learned a new language, built a career, raised a child, and maintained her sense of purpose and peace through it all. She did not do this by following some complicated formula or chasing

after the latest happiness trends. She did it by staying true to simple but profound principles. Value your family. Finishing what you start. Learn from your mistakes. Be grateful for what you have. Find work that means something to you. These are not flashy or trendy ideas, but they have sustained her through challenges that would have broken up many people.

As I move forward in my own life, I will carry these lessons with me. When I face difficult situations, I will remember my mother's resilience and her refusal to give up halfway through. When I struggle with choices, I will remember her emphasis on honesty and staying true to your values. When I feel disconnected or alone, I will remember her conviction that family and close relationships are what give life meaning. And when I am tempted to dwell on past mistakes or missed opportunities, I will remember her approach to regrets, acknowledging them but refusing to be defined by them, learning from them and moving forward with gratitude.

This interview was more than just an assignment. It was a gift. It gave me the opportunity to sit down with my mother and really listen to her in a way that our daily conversations do not always allow. It helped me understand not just what she believes, but why she believes it and how her beliefs have been forged through real struggles. And it showed me that the good life she talks about is not some distant ideal or abstract concept. It is something she has built through conscious choices, through commitment to what matters most, through resilience in the face of challenges, and through gratitude for what she has. She has created a good life, and in doing so she has shown me how to create one for myself.

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Thank you card for my mother:

